

Mobilising worker support for Just Transition policies: Testing the ‘Union Effect’

Introduction

As the EU accelerates its climate agenda under frameworks like the European Green Deal, Fit for 55, and the Just Transition Mechanism, it has become clear that the **political sustainability of decarbonisation policies hinges on more than their environmental rationale.**

As part of its Just Transition agenda, the EU today supports key industrial regions such as Eastern Wielkopolska in Poland, Lusatia in Germany, or the Hauts-de-France in France, **territories where climate policy meets longstanding economic dependency on coal, heavy industry, or automotive manufacturing.**

Today, we yet strive to know more about the **effectiveness of these tools in securing lasting political support** among workers at risk of job loss and communities facing long-term economic restructuring.

Research objectives and contributions

When are workers willing to support climate measures that may put their current jobs at risk? How does the position taken by trade unions shape those views?

This study first aims to understand the impact of different Just Transition strategies on climate policy support. For this, we distinguish between compensation (**targeted support to affected workers**) and community approaches (**long-term rejuvenation** of affected regions) and evaluate the relative impact of these approaches.

The second arm of this study explores the role of unions and other worker organisations in shaping how these policies are perceived by workers. We look at **how the credibility and visibility of union support can build trust in climate-related reforms.**

Ultimately, our project seeks to identify politically sustainable Just Transition strategies while offering unions with practical tools to **anticipate challenges and strengthen worker engagement in different contexts.**

Methods and data

To ensure that our results reflect the concerns of those most affected, we are recruiting a **representative sample of 1,500 workers in sectors vulnerable to decarbonization policies** across EU countries. The survey will be distributed in collaboration with unions and employers networks.

We conduct a **large-scale survey experiment** which includes realistic climate transition scenarios. Participants are asked to choose between different Just Transition policy packages, each combining different policy instruments, including financial compensation, job guarantees, retraining

opportunities, or community investments. These features are based on a comprehensive review of **real-world policy dilemmas and Just Transition agreements adopted across the EU.**

Through a vignette experiment, we further assess **whether union support increases trust in envisaged plans, encourages worker participation in shaping the transition, and ultimately contributes to their realignment behind climate action.**

Your role

Your support in circulating the questionnaire will help us **gather a more representative and credible evidence base**, capturing the voices of those most directly affected by climate policies.

Your contribution will help us to deliver **insights that can inform collective bargaining, policy advocacy, and the design of workers-informed just transition plans.**

Output

To ensure the results are both useful and actionable for our partners, we propose several forms of dissemination:

Project partners will receive **early access to survey findings and a summary highlighting relevant insights** to their organisations.

We will also organise **dissemination events** to discuss the policy implications of the results.

Further dissemination tools may also be considered, for instance in the form of a **policy brief**, helping to translate the findings into proposals for reform at EU level.

Project partners

This project is currently supported by the École Polytechnique Fédérale de Lausanne (EPFL) and the Freie Universität Berlin. Partnership with our alma mater institution, the European University Institute (EUI), has been secured.

To ensure the research is policy-relevant and widely disseminated, we are engaging with a range of **institutional partners and expert organisations.** These include units within the European Commission, the Committee of the Regions.

The survey design has been submitted to the EPFL's Institutional Review Board (IRB) to ensure full ethical compliance.

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